English took control of the town in 1825 though this was punctuated by its loss, first to the rebel Palayakkarars and later to the Dutch. Notwithstanding Sinnappah Arasaratnam's observation that 'Tuticorin grew as the major port to the west of the Palk Straits after its conquest and fortification by the Portuguese, and then by the Dutch',[64] at the time of the First World War the *Tinnevelly District Gazetteer* noted that 'the rise of Tuticorin to a position of importance in the world of commerce is a matter of comparatively recent history'. It added for good measure that 'it is probable that few ports in India have experienced so rapid a development'.[65]

Even in the early nineteenth century, Kayalpatnam and Kulasekarapatnam were flourishing centres of coastal trade in the district while Tuticorin was of little importance. But in the context of the rise of coastal trade and its position in the larger Indian Ocean trade route in the age of steam, outlined above, Tuticorin prospered. Cotton held pride of place in the trade, and Tuticorin shipped a huge volume of cotton ('Tinnies' as the variety was called) grown in the district. Even though the first cotton export to Liverpool was in 1831,[66] it received a fillip only with the cotton boom of the 1860s following the American Civil War which disrupted the supplies from the American South to England.[67] The main street in Tuticorin, which hits the Beach Road, still goes by the name of Great Cotton Road.

Tuticorin had no docks, pontoons, patent ships or quays. A late nineteenth-century handbook of ports described the harbour 'as extensive but shallow, the depth of water near the town and jetty being only 6½ feet', and was therefore visited only by small native crafts involved in the coasting trade.[68]

But as trade grew, planned development began in 1868 when the first pier —a rudimentary wooden jetty of barely a hundred feet—was constructed. Some years later it was extended and strengthened, a process that was repeated in every subsequent decade.[69] By the turn of the twentieth century, there was an iron screw pile pier of 600 feet. While there was a small wooden jetty for light work, some of the bigger British firms had their own